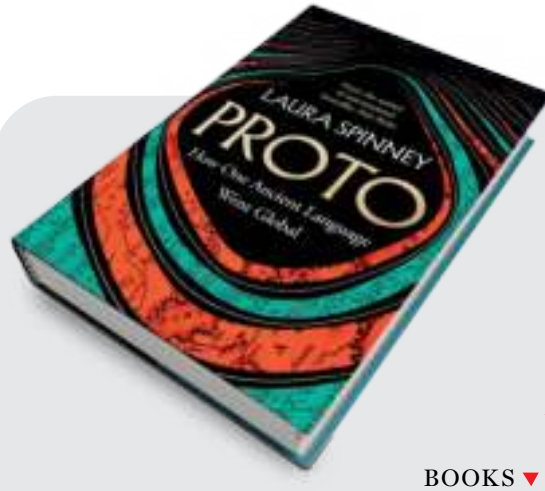
early to mid first millennium CE, around the same time temple-based practices, sati and widow remarriage prohibitions "emerged or were solidified". "Even in 2025, Hinduism is a notably diverse religion, but nearly all of its signature features we know today emerged within the last 2,000 years, with a number occurring during the 18th and 19th-century Hindu reform movements," says Truschke. "Two things that go back to the beginning (i.e., the Vedic period around 3,000 years ago) are an emphasis on ritual and an embrace of plurality. People ask how Hinduism has survived so long, and it is certainly an outlier in longevity. The answer is that Hinduism changed to survive, over and over."

Even for Truschke, a professor of South Asian history, there were surprising revelations. "One that stands out in my mind concerns the love story around the Taj Mahal, which Shah Jahan built for his deceased wife, Mumtaz Mahal," she says. "I had long discounted the romantic tale that they shared a genuine love. However, upon reviewing the evidence, I now think it's more likely than not that they shared genuine affection, a rarity indeed among Indian royalty." ■

—Bhavya Dore



PROTO How One Ancient Language Went Global
By Laura Spinney
WILLIAM COLLINS
₹599; 352 pages

BOOKS ▼

Mother Tongue

LAURA SPINNEY'S *PROTO* IS AN ACCESSIBLE GUIDE TO THE ORIGINS OF INDO-EUROPEAN LANGUAGES

Are you the kind of reader who knows your R1a from their R1b? Your Yamanaya from your Sintashta? Corded Ware from Bell-Beaker? Your Cucuteni-Trypillia from your Hurrians? A 'yes' at any point in this inquisition is a dealmaker: Laura Spinney's *Proto* is a book for you...Nerd.

In fact, this book joins a clutch of remarkably popular volumes addressing the seemingly arcane intersection of archaeological, genetic and linguistic research into the peopling of the globe. *Proto* is an account of the origins and dispersal of Indo-European languages, now spoken by more than half the world. It's a story that runs from the hypothesised 'Ursprache' (Proto Indo-European, or PIE), Urheimat (most likely the Eurasian steppe) and Urvolk (a fecund, fast-moving and arguably violence-prone community of early bronze age nomadic pastoralists) to several clusters of linguistic descendants. Some of these, such as the Anatolian and Tocharian languages, are now extinct. Others such as the Indo-Iranian family, from which most North Indian languages derive, are still vital or even viral. A science journalist, whose prescient previous book, *Pale Rider* (2017), was about the Spanish Flu pandemic of 1918, Spinney is a confident narrator of complex subjects that require glosses of technical detail as well as expansive historical or geographical context.

***PROTO* ADDRESSES THE INTERSECTION OF ARCHAEOLOGICAL, GENETIC AND LINGUISTIC RESEARCH INTO THE PEOPLING OF THE WORLD**

In *Proto*, she has taken on a fast-moving area of research where work is often updated or superseded with brutal speed. Yet, she has an engaging conversational pace and a talent for the evanescent moment—whether it's tea and conversation with the late archaeologist Colin Renfrew or witnessing the excavation of a Yamanaya kurgan (a Bronze Age burial mound) amidst the Russian offensive on Ukraine.

Unfortunately, *Proto* is marred by a small but persistent confusion about Sanskrit epigraphy. At several points in her narrative, Spinney informs us that the Rig Veda was 'written' in or around 1500 BC. While this is a date conventionally ascribed to the composition of this text, Spinney seems to suggest there is physical evidence of a Sanskrit/Vedic document of this antiquity. In fact, the earliest deciphered writing in India is in the form of the Ashokan edicts from 260 BC, more than a millennium later. And even these are not, of course, Vedic or in Sanskrit. (Nor, strictly speaking, are the 1500 BC texts from the Mitanni kingdom in Syria that Spinney also gestures at.)

This puzzling lapse may be particularly disconcerting for South Asian readers, since it does a disservice to the remarkable oral traditions surrounding the Vedic corpus, while also playing into the more recent tendency to exaggerate the antiquity of all things Indic. Hopefully, Spinney will address the confusion in a future edition of this otherwise absorbing and informative book. ■

—Kai Friese